Vegetarian Cabbage Rolls

FROM NELL'S KITCHEN

Tender cabbage leaves wrapped around rice, tomatoes, fresh herbs and pine nuts make a generous dish for the table.

Serves 6–8 · Prep 50 min · Cook 1 h 30

INGREDIENTS

- 1 small cabbage
- 1 cup uncooked rice, rinsed and drained
- 1 bunch flat-leaf parsley, finely chopped
- ½ bunch fresh mint, leaves picked and finely chopped
- 800 g ripe tomatoes, finely chopped, with their juices
- ½ cup pine nuts
- 2 cups fresh lemon juice
- 1 cup olive oil
- 1½ tbsp pomegranate molasses
- 1 tbsp salt
- Water, only as needed to top up the cooking liquid

METHOD

1. Soften the cabbage leaves. Bring a large pot of water to the boil. Carefully remove the cabbage core, then lower the cabbage into the water. As the outer leaves soften, loosen them with tongs and lift them out. Continue until you have separated the usable leaves. They should be pliable enough to roll without becoming mushy.
2. Drain the leaves and allow them to cool. Trim away the thick central ribs, reserving these and any torn leaves to line the cooking pot. Cut the larger leaves into smaller sections suitable for rolling.
3. Make the filling. In a large bowl, combine the uncooked rice, parsley, mint, tomatoes and their juices, pine nuts, lemon juice, olive oil, pomegranate molasses and salt. Mix thoroughly.
4. Drain and reserve the juices. Set a sieve or colander over a large bowl. Spoon in the filling and let the liquid drain into the bowl underneath. Keep all these juices for cooking.
5. Fill and roll. Lay a cabbage leaf flat and place a small, slender line of filling near one edge. Roll the leaf around the filling, leaving both ends open without folding in the sides. Keep the roll neat but allow room for the rice to expand. Repeat with the remaining leaves and filling.
6. Arrange in the pot. Line the base of a heavy cooking pot with the reserved cabbage ribs and torn leaves. Arrange the rolls snugly in layers, seam-side down.
7. Add the cooking juices. Pour the reserved liquid from the filling over the rolls. Add just enough water, if needed, to barely cover the top layer. Place a heatproof plate over the rolls to keep them in place.
8. Cook gently. Bring to a gentle simmer, cover the pot and reduce the heat to low. Cook for approximately 1–1½ hours, until the cabbage is tender and the rice is fully cooked. Check occasionally and add a little hot water if the liquid runs low before the rice is ready.
9. Rest and refrigerate. Remove from the heat and leave to settle for 15 minutes. Carefully remove the plate and transfer the rolls to shallow containers, spooning over some cooking juices. Refrigerate promptly for at least 1 hour, or until cold.
10. Serve cold. Arrange the chilled rolls on a serving platter and spoon over a little of their juices.

Tip

Keep the rice uncooked. It cooks inside the cabbage and absorbs the flavourful juices.